

Growing up Barefoot

My father quit school when he was 16 and began working at a service station in Ouyen, a tiny wheat-belt town in the Mallee. (Claim to fame? It's the hottest place in Victoria. And it has the best vanilla slices. Think about that combo.)

One fateful day the bell on the servo door chimed, and in walked the most beautiful girl Dad had ever seen.

Her name was Joan.

The way my father tells the story, he instantly knew she was 'the one'.

My mother, the more conservative of the two, was more circumspect, and with good reason. Looking back at the polaroids of my parents when they were dating, I see a young man with mutton-chop sideburns, flares and a look in his eyes that I know only too well. It said: 'I'm batting above my weight with this girl, so I need to give this everything I've got.'

And for the next 40 years, he did (and continues to).

He worked day and night at that servo. In fact, he was there so much that he lived in the caravan out the back for a while, saving his shekels. And it worked. Years later he bought that servo.

When my parents got hitched they built our family home, a functional fibro joint located at the top of what the locals called 'Tickle Belly Hill'. True dinks, we'd actually have mail addressed and delivered to 'Tickle Belly Hill'.

I came into the world at Ouyen Hospital, but, unfortunately for my mother, I was born dangerously close to the VFL Grand Final. So after she checked herself out of hospital(!), she arrived home and was greeted by Dad and his mates—including the doctor who'd delivered me—downing frothies in the living room, watching the footy.